

► Painted white leather apron

The Freemasons adopted the apron, an echo of the pouch in which a medieval Mason kept his tools. As here, it often shows emblems such as the square (right-angled tool, seen at bottom left) and compasses used by architects.

Secret brotherhood

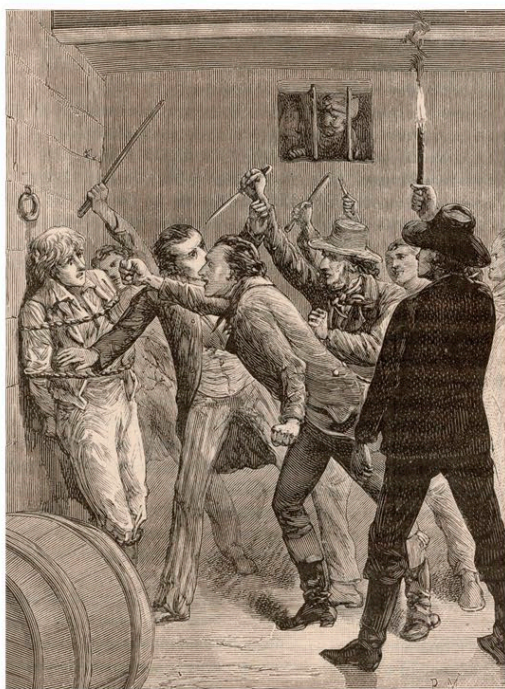
Every lodge and every arm of Freemasonry is independent—there is no higher coordinating body. Together with its strands from the past, this flexibility helps explain its appeal. Largely a product of the English-speaking world, the first Masonic lodge in America was begun in 1730, and Benjamin Franklin was a founding member.

Today there are Freemasons across much of Europe, particularly in France, as well as in many parts of Latin America. The public focus of the Masons in the UK and US is on good works, but in Latin America an “occult-esoteric” bias is clear, which emphasizes alchemy and its power to transform, though spiritually rather than physically.

Freemasonry has always invited suspicion, particularly from critics who view it as a closed world of shadowy influence bent on the creation of a New World Order. It has much in common with another secret brotherhood, the late 18th-century Illuminati, which also searched for universal truth. Other critics claim that its stress on “brotherhood, relief [charity], and truth” are mere distractions



from the promotion of the interests of its overwhelmingly white male members (nearly all lodges exclude women). Nor has Freemasonry spread to the Islamic world, where it is illegal in most regions. Yet it remains a modern-day survival of supposedly ancient lore and custom, with mysticism and private rituals at its heart.



IN CONTEXT

Scandal and outrage

The disappearance of journalist William Morgan in New York in 1826 was taken as clear evidence of the sinister potency of Freemasonry. A one-time member himself, he was presumed to have been murdered by the Freemasons for having revealed their secrets. No proof of his death at the hands of Freemasons was ever found but lack of evidence only increased a fevered speculation. Many assumed the Freemasons were guilty. Morgan's disappearance provoked a rapid anti-Masonic reaction in the US that sent the movement into decline until a sudden revival in the Civil War (1861–1865) thanks to testimony of Freemasons' compassionate acts.

According to this 1826 engraving, Freemasons murdered Morgan for revealing secrets he had learned when he was a member.